## Bites & Banter

**WHERE:** Kochi, Kerala

**WHO:** The trio behind Smatchet Deli—Anna Josekuttan Pynadath (Annamoi), George Mayne and Georgy Vinod—have extended their aesthetic sense and culinary knowledge to this fortnightly feast that people travel to attend

**WHY**: Each themed seven-course meal, called an 'episode', is cuisine agnostic, starring diverse techniques and tales. For example, the first one in May 2024 was named 'Burnt Butter & Bad Jokes' and was all about whipped burnt butter on sourdough, tortellini stuffed with pastrami, wild greens topped with roasted beets and fennel, potato pavé with roasted pumpkin and cauliflower purée, cured sliced beef with chicken pâté, and other cured, aged, and smoked offerings. The second episode, hosted at Brunton Boatyard in Fort Kochi, is 'Forgotten Cochin', celebrating the varied influences on the city's food traditions. Ancestral recipes, traditional wedding fare reinvented, and gourmet twists on childhood faves like Dutch rose cookies, all bring alive the culinary history of Kochi with the trio's trademark flair

**HOW:** Flight to Kochi



*A Queen's Surprise, a dessert at Bites & Banter*



*A traditional Monpa meal at Damu's Heritage Dine*

PRIANKO BISWAS

## Damu's Heritage Dine

**WHERE:** Chug Valley, Dirang, Arunachal Pradesh

**WHO:** A collective of eight women from the Monpa tribe take pride in presenting their cuisine in an ancient Arunachali home. Chef Farha Naaz Laskar (known for her appearance in *Masterchef India* and Guwahati's Mamzaki food pop up) and Nishant Sinha, a sustainable tourism practitioner with WWF India, have helped hone their expertise to appeal to everyone, even elite eaterati

**WHY:** An 11-seater eatery that focuses on foraged ingredients, and offers a variety of dishes using local cheese, pulled Mithun meat, millets, beans, corn and Monpa orange

**HOW:** Flight to Guwahati and 303 km by road